

A Speculative Model of a Submerged Late Ice Age Atlantic Civilization and Its Possible Cultural Continuities in New England

Abstract

This paper presents a speculative macrohistorical theory proposing the existence of a sophisticated Late Pleistocene or early Holocene Atlantic coastal civilization whose primary habitation zones were subsequently submerged by post-glacial sea-level rise and heavily altered by glaciation, sedimentation, and ecological succession. The theory further proposes that fragmented survivals of this civilization—including lithic architecture, maritime traditions, symbolic systems, and

inherited construction techniques—persisted through later Atlantic cultures, including Indigenous peoples of Northeastern North America, Norse explorers, Celtic maritime groups, and potentially other seafaring populations.

Particular attention is given to anomalous stone structures and lithic landscapes in New Hampshire and the broader New England region, including oversized megalithic stones, dry-stone chambers, partially buried lower courses, and apparent architectural similarities to Atlantic megalithic traditions observed in Europe. The model suggests that many visible colonial-era stone walls may incorporate or rest upon significantly older anthropogenic substrates obscured through glacial activity, forest succession, and later human reuse.

This theory does not claim definitive proof of a lost civilization. Rather, it proposes an alternative interpretive framework integrating paleoclimatology, archaeology, oral tradition,

comparative megalithic architecture, post-glacial geography, and civilizational collapse theory. The paper argues that modern archaeological assumptions may underestimate the complexity and antiquity of human coastal societies prior to Holocene sea-level rise and that submerged archaeology may represent one of the largest missing datasets in human history.

Keywords: Atlantic civilization hypothesis, post-glacial sea-level rise, New Hampshire stone walls, megalithic architecture, submerged archaeology, Late Ice Age cultures, lithic reuse, cultural continuity



Introduction

Modern historical narratives generally portray advanced civilization as a relatively recent and regionally isolated development emerging

independently within a limited number of agricultural cradles. Under this framework, the stone structures of New England are typically interpreted as products of colonial agricultural clearing, Indigenous ceremonial activity, or natural geological processes shaped by glaciation.

This paper proposes a broader and more speculative alternative model.

The theory advanced here suggests that prior to the end of the Last Glacial Maximum, significant human populations occupied now-submerged Atlantic coastal regions exposed during periods of lower sea level. These populations may have developed sophisticated maritime knowledge, large-scale lithic construction traditions, and complex symbolic or cosmological systems. As global temperatures rose and glacial melting accelerated during the transition into the Holocene, many of these coastal habitation zones were inundated, fragmented, or destroyed.

The surviving northern territories of this civilization, particularly in regions later affected by glacial grinding, sediment accumulation, and ecological succession, may have been partially buried or structurally degraded. Later populations—including Indigenous Northeastern cultures, Atlantic maritime peoples, and eventually European settlers—may then have reused, inherited, mythologized, or reconstructed portions of these older lithic landscapes.

Under this model, the stone chambers, anomalous wall systems, and megalithic features of New England are not necessarily isolated colonial constructions, but possible remnants of layered cultural continuity extending far deeper into prehistory than currently assumed.



The Post-Glacial Transformation of the Atlantic World

During the Last Glacial Maximum approximately 20,000 years ago, global sea levels were dramatically lower than today, exposing vast continental shelf regions throughout the Atlantic basin. Coastlines extended significantly farther outward, creating expansive habitable zones along what are now submerged margins of North America and Europe.

Paleoclimatic evidence confirms that the termination of the Ice Age resulted in substantial sea-level rise during the late Pleistocene and early Holocene. Entire coastal plains, estuaries, river valleys, and maritime settlement zones would have gradually disappeared beneath rising oceans.

This process creates a major archaeological asymmetry: the regions most favorable to early human habitation—including temperate coasts, estuaries, fisheries, and navigable waterways—

are now among the least accessible to archaeology.

Consequently, modern understandings of prehistoric civilization may be heavily biased toward inland survivals rather than coastal population centers that no longer exist above water.

The theory proposed here argues that this submerged archaeological record may represent one of the largest missing components in the reconstruction of early human civilization.



Glaciation and the Destruction of Northern Archaeological Continuity

In addition to marine inundation, northern regions such as New England experienced intense glacial activity during the Pleistocene.

Advancing and retreating ice sheets fractured bedrock, redistributed massive quantities of lithic material, buried landscapes beneath glacial till, and altered hydrological systems on continental scales.

Under conventional interpretations, this geological activity explains the abundance of surface stone throughout New England and the prevalence of later colonial stone walls.

However, this paper proposes that glacial processes may also have obscured, fragmented, or partially buried earlier anthropogenic structures.

If pre-existing lithic features once existed within the region, later glacial grinding, sediment deposition, frost heaving, and forest succession could have transformed surviving ruins into ambiguous formations difficult to distinguish from natural geology or colonial reuse.

In this context, many apparently isolated stone anomalies may represent only the visible remnants of far older and more extensive

systems.



Megalithic Architectural Convergence and Shared Construction Logic

One of the central observations motivating this theory is the apparent architectural similarity between certain New England stone structures and megalithic traditions observed throughout Atlantic Europe.

These similarities include:

rectangular granite liths;

dry-stone chamber construction;

corbeling techniques;

cyclopean stone placement;

lintel-supported chamber entrances;

terraced stone systems;

and apparent astronomical or directional orientations.

Conventional archaeology generally interprets such similarities as examples of convergent architectural evolution. Because stone obeys universal physical constraints, different societies may independently arrive at comparable engineering solutions.

While convergent development undoubtedly explains some similarities, proponents of the present theory argue that the degree of resemblance occasionally exceeds what would be expected from purely independent development.

In particular, builders familiar with lithic engineering often recognize similarities not merely in appearance, but in construction logic itself:

load transfer strategies,

fracture selection,

placement rhythm,

stone shaping behavior,

and overall structural intent.

Under this model, such similarities may reflect distant survivals or inherited fragments of a broader Atlantic megalithic tradition originating prior to post-glacial fragmentation.



Cultural Fragmentation and the Survival of Inherited Traditions

As coastlines disappeared and populations fragmented, surviving groups may have carried partial remnants of earlier knowledge systems into later civilizations.

This process may help explain:

recurring flood myths;

shared cosmological motifs;

giant-builder traditions;

maritime religious symbolism;

solar and stellar alignments;

and parallel megalithic traditions distributed across Atlantic-facing cultures.

The theory proposes that later peoples—including Indigenous Northeastern groups, Norse voyagers, Celtic maritime cultures, and Phoenician traders—did not necessarily create identical traditions independently, but inherited fragments of much older symbolic and architectural continuities whose original context had already been lost.

Under this interpretation, many mythological narratives traditionally dismissed as purely symbolic may preserve distorted cultural memories of environmental catastrophe, coastal inundation, and civilizational collapse during the transition out of the Ice Age.

This model does not require a technologically

modern “super-civilization.” Rather, it proposes a sophisticated maritime culture whose achievements were later fragmented, mythologized, and partially erased through environmental upheaval.



New England as a Zone of Cultural and Structural Survival

New England occupies a potentially significant position within this framework due to its geological history, Atlantic orientation, and unusually dense lithic landscape.

The forests of New Hampshire in particular contain:

extensive dry-stone wall systems;

anomalous chambers;

isolated lithic structures;

oversized embedded stones;

and partially buried formations difficult to interpret conclusively.

The dominant explanation attributes these features primarily to colonial agricultural activity, and substantial evidence supports this interpretation in many cases.

However, this theory proposes that later colonial populations may have frequently reused, extended, or reconstructed preexisting lithic alignments already present within the landscape.

Under this model:

colonial walls become secondary structures;

visible stone systems represent only upper exposed layers;

and deeper buried courses may preserve significantly older anthropogenic continuity.

The theory further proposes that many apparent “ruins” in New England forests may not

represent isolated structures, but the fragmented remnants of once-larger integrated systems obscured by glaciation, collapse, vegetation growth, and human reuse over millennia.



Technological Regression and Historical Compression

A major component of this theory is the idea that human history is less linear than commonly portrayed.

Rather than civilization progressing steadily upward, the archaeological record may reflect repeated cycles of:

expansion,

fragmentation,

environmental catastrophe,

technological loss,

and cultural reinvention.

Under this framework, many ancient technologies or engineering capabilities may have been partially forgotten following periods of collapse, only to later re-emerge independently or through inherited fragments.

Examples frequently cited in support of nonlinear historical development include:

Roman concrete formulations;

Bronze Age collapse;

lost navigational methods;

large-scale ancient stoneworking;

and the rediscovery of astronomical alignments in prehistoric architecture.

The theory advanced here extends this pattern into deeper prehistory, proposing that post-glacial fragmentation compressed humanity's memory of earlier maritime and lithic traditions into mythology, religion, and partially inherited

engineering practices.



Toward a Research Framework

Although highly speculative, this theory generates testable predictions.

Potential avenues for investigation include:

offshore sonar mapping of submerged Atlantic shelves;

LiDAR analysis of New England stone networks;

stratigraphic excavation beneath visible wall systems;

lichenometric and sediment dating of buried lithic courses;

GIS-based geometric pattern analysis;

comparative megalithic engineering studies;

and interdisciplinary analysis integrating

archaeology, paleoclimatology, oral traditions, and maritime anthropology.

The strongest version of the theory depends not upon mythology alone, but upon the accumulation of convergent empirical anomalies difficult to explain through conventional models independently.



Conclusion

The theory presented in this paper proposes that a substantial portion of humanity's early coastal history may now lie submerged beneath post-glacial oceans and fragmented beneath glaciated landscapes. Within this framework, the anomalous stone structures and lithic systems of New England may represent surviving traces of a far older Atlantic cultural continuum subsequently inherited, reused, and

mythologized by later peoples.

At present, definitive archaeological evidence for such a civilization remains absent, and many observed anomalies may ultimately prove explainable through conventional geological and historical models. Nevertheless, the rapid evolution of underwater archaeology, remote sensing technologies, and paleoclimatic reconstruction suggests that current understandings of prehistoric human civilization may remain incomplete.

If nothing else, the possibility of extensive submerged cultural landscapes challenges the assumption that the archaeological record preserved on land represents the totality of early human development.

The surviving stones of New England may therefore represent not merely colonial boundaries, but layered historical echoes emerging through the erosion, burial, and reconstruction of deep time itself.